

Writing and printing

People began to write things down about 5,500 years ago. Before this, they told stories and passed news on by word of mouth.

Today, writing is all around you.

The alphabet

Fountain pens are filled with ink.

Signs and symbols

Sometimes, signs and symbols are used to write letters and words, or even secret codes.

Pictograms are pictures used for writing. This old Chinese word means "to sell".



Hieroglyphs were used by the ancient Egyptians. This one stands for "chick".



Runes were Viking symbols that were carved on stone or wood. This is the "M" sound.



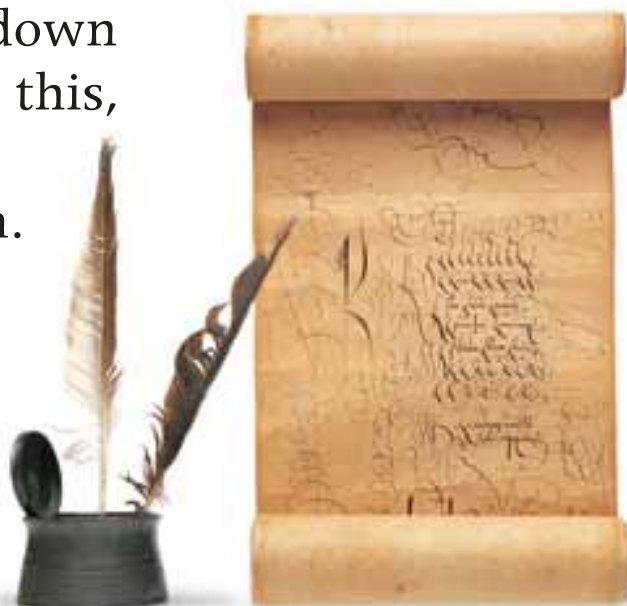
Music symbols like these are used to write down musical sounds (notes).



Morse code changes the alphabet into dot and dash signals for sending messages.



Quill pens in a pot of ink with a scroll made from papyrus reeds



Paper and pens

The paper you use today comes from trees. Long ago, people made paper from reeds or animal skins. The first pens were pieces of reeds, dipped in soot or ink.

Writing machines

The first typewriters were invented about 200 years ago. They made writing much quicker. Today, word processors, like this laptop computer, are used instead.



Early typewriter



Laptop computer